CHAPTER 7

AN IMPERIAL CAPITAL VIJAYANAGARA

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:
Master the Vijayanagara Empire (1336-1565): Tungabhadra hydrology, fortification enclosing agricultural fields, royal center architecture (Mahanavami Dibba, Lotus Mahal), and Nayaka administration.

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Foundational Ecology and River Hydrology:** Founded in 1336 by Harihara and Bukka in the rocky granite basin of the Tungabhadra; engineered advanced rainwater harvesting: Kamalapuram tank and Hiriya canal.

• **Concentric Seven-Fold Fortification:** Persian ambassador Abdur Razzaq recorded seven concentric rings of defensive walls enclosing not just palaces, but vast agricultural fields and granaries to survive prolonged sieges.

• **Royal Center and Mahanavami Dibba:** The Royal Center featured monumental secular and civic structures; the massive stone platform 'Mahanavami Dibba' hosted imperial Navaratri ceremonies, animal sacrifices, and military reviews.

• **Sacred Center and Amara-Nayaka System:** Sacred Center housed historic riverfront temples (Virupaksha, Vitthala with musical pillars); Amara-Nayakas were military commanders given territories (amaram) who collected revenue and supplied royal troops.

ESSENTIAL HISTORICAL CHRONOLOGIES & THEMES

$$\text{Vijayanagara Foundation} \iff \text{Harihara and Bukka (1336)} \rightarrow \text{Tungabhadra Granite Basin}$$
Origins of the City of Victory in 14th Century Deccan

$$\text{Abdur Razzaq Fortification Topology} \iff \text{7 Concentric Walls} \rightarrow \text{Agricultural Fields Enclosed}$$
Seven-Fold Defensive Agrarian Siege Architecture

$$\text{Mahanavami Platform Ritual} \iff \text{State Sacrifice} + \text{Wrestling/Pageantry} + \text{Nayaka Fealty Tribute}$$
Royal Center Legitimation and Vassal Review Ceremony

$$\text{Amara-Nayaka Military Administration} \iff \text{Amaram Fief} \longleftrightarrow \text{Troop Contingent and Annual Tribute}$$
Provincial Feudo-Military Administrative System

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** Vijayanagara fortifications were constructed without mortar or cementing agent; wedge-shaped stones held together by interlocking joints.

• **Alert:** Domingo Paes described Krishnadeva Raya as an intellectual and military genius who authored the Telugu work on statecraft 'Amuktamalyada'.

• **Alert:** The Battle of Talikota (Rakshasi-Tangadi) in 1565 witnessed the combined armies of Bijapur, Golconda, and Ahmadnagar completely defeat and sack the imperial city of Vijayanagara.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. Describe the unique features of the fortification of Vijayanagara as recorded by Abdur Razzaq. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Seven Concentric Enclosures:** Abdur Razzaq, an envoy from Persia, recorded that the city was protected by seven concentric lines of fortified walls. **[1 Mark]**

• **Enclosure of Agricultural Lands:** The outermost walls encircled not just urban dwellings, but extensive cultivated fields, orchards, gardens, and granaries to survive multi-year sieges. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Dry Masonry Construction:** Massive wedge-shaped granite blocks were fitted together without any mortar or cementing agent, using interlocking joints. **[1.5 Marks]**

2. What was the Mahanavami Dibba? Describe the ceremonies associated with it. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Structure:** A massive stone platform rising from a base of about 11,000 square feet to a height of 40 feet, carved with reliefs of horses, elephants, and dancers. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Ceremonies:** Center for the nine-day Hindu festival known as Mahanavami (Navaratri) in September-October. **[1 Mark]**

• **Ritual Acts:** Included state worship of the royal horse, animal sacrifices (buffaloes), wrestling matches, and a grand ceremonial inspection of army contingents and tribute payments by Amara-Nayakas. **[1.5 Marks]**

3. Explain the features of the Amara-Nayaka system in Vijayanagara administration. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Military Fiefs:** The Amara-Nayakas were military commanders assigned territories (called amaram) by the Raya (king) to govern and collect taxes from peasants and artisans. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Obligations:** Maintained a stipulated contingent of horses, elephants, and foot soldiers for the king's army, and personally visited the royal court annually with gifts and tribute. **[1.5 Marks]**

4. How did the rulers of Vijayanagara manage their water resources in a semi-arid zone? [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Natural Basin:** The Tungabhadra flows in a north-easterly direction; granite hills surrounded the city, forming a natural water catchment basin. **[1 Mark]**

• **Embankments and Tanks:** Rulers constructed massive stone bunds across streams to create reservoirs; the celebrated Kamalapuram tank irrigated fields and supplied piped water to the Royal Center. **[1 Mark]**

• **Hiriya Canal:** Built by Sangama kings, drawing water from a dam across the Tungabhadra to irrigate the fertile valley between the Sacred and Urban centers. **[1 Mark]**

5. Who was the most famous ruler of Vijayanagara? Mention his literary work. [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Ruler:** Krishnadeva Raya (ruled 1509-1529) of the Tuluva dynasty. **[1 Mark]**

• **Literary Work:** Authored 'Amuktamalyada', an acclaimed treatise on statecraft and administrative policy in the Telugu language. **[1 Mark]**

6. When was the Battle of Talikota fought? What was its outcome? [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Date and Combatants:** Fought in 1565 CE between the Vijayanagara army under Rama Raya and the combined forces of Bijapur, Ahmadnagar, and Golconda. **[1 Mark]**

• **Outcome:** The Vijayanagara army was decisively crushed, Rama Raya was captured and executed, and the magnificent capital city was sacked and permanently abandoned. **[1 Mark]**